

Why Artemis II used Nikon cameras

Back in 2024, NASA announced their partnership with Nikon for the Artemis programme. In their initial announcement, they told how the team performed their testing on a standard Nikon Z9 camera to determine the specifications a camera would need to operate on the lunar surface.

After this, the design of the Z9 camera was modified along with Nikkor lenses with NASA's thermal blanket to protect the camera from dust and extreme temperatures. A custom grip with modified buttons was also added to use the camera even when they have their gloves on.

Yet another question that comes to mind is that while using



the Nikon Z9 for its space-ready capabilities makes sense, why did NASA also decide on carrying over the 10-year-old Nikon D5 with them? After all, it's not even

a modern mirrorless camera, but rather a much older DSLR instead.

The answer might surprise you, but it's purely because of the imaging the D5 provides. Even after so many years and so many new camera releases, the Nikon D5 remains the best-ever digital camera for high ISO performance. The more modern Z9 tops out at ISO 102,400, while the D5's ISO range extends up to 3,280,000, roughly 30 times higher than the Z9. During missions such as Artemis II, where the crew would be shooting the dark side of the Moon, a higher ISO number would be required. Now you know why!

—Madhav Banka

The iPhone 17 also flew past the moon!

When the Artemis II spacecraft launched on April 1, 2026 – marking humanity's first crewed mission to lunar space in over 50 years – each of the four astronauts aboard had an iPhone 17 Pro Max tucked into their flight suit. Not a custom space



camera. Not a purpose engineered NASA device. The same phone that millions have bought since it was released september last year. Getting it there, however, was anything but simple.

For every hazard identified, NASA needed a plan. For the iPhone, this meant disabling all wireless connectivity – no cellular, no Wi-Fi, no Bluetooth – to prevent any interference with Orion's navigation systems. Physical handling was addressed too, phones would be secured with Velcro mounts inside the cabin, or zipped into leg pockets on flight suits before launch. NASA then validated that the mitigations actually held up. The iPhone's Ceramic Shield 2 display had to demonstrate sufficient durability, and the physical storage solutions had to be tested as genuinely effective.

Once aboard, the iPhones function only as high-quality cameras. No internet, no Bluetooth, no FaceTime with the family. The crew has already used them to capture striking images of Earth from deep space, which NASA has been sharing publicly. Apple, for its part, had no involvement whatsoever in the approval process. NASA handled it independently. The company did confirm, though, that this marks the first time an iPhone has been fully qualified for extended use in orbit and beyond.

—Vyom Ramani